



EXECUTIVE AI PORTFOLIO DECISION GUIDE

AI Use Case Prioritization Guide 2026

A disciplined method for selecting AI investments with credible value and delivery paths

Prepared for Chief executives, product, technology, operations, finance and transformation leaders

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Purpose

This guide helps leadership convert a long list of AI ideas into a governed investment portfolio. It separates attractive demonstrations from initiatives with a defensible customer problem, economic case, data foundation, implementation path and acceptable risk.

EXECUTIVE DECISION DASHBOARD

Management View at a Glance

The best first AI use case is rarely the most technically impressive. It is the initiative with material value, a bounded workflow, accessible data, credible adoption, controlled risk and a short path to measurable evidence.

Executive question	ROALLA view	Decision implication
Is the idea tied to strategy?	CONDITIONAL	Link the use case to a priority outcome, owner and baseline.
Can value be measured quickly?	PURSUE	Prefer initiatives with observable outcomes inside one or two operating cycles.
Are feasibility and risk understood?	PREPARE	Complete data, architecture, privacy, security and adoption screening.
Is the portfolio balanced?	DECIDE	Balance quick wins, foundational capabilities and selective strategic bets.
What should management authorize?	PURSUE	A scored use-case funnel and two controlled discovery sprints.

Recommended Management Posture

Proceed through a small number of explicit decision gates. Preserve evidence as work occurs, separate discovery from implementation, and require each investment to demonstrate value, feasibility, control effectiveness and accountable ownership before scale.

EXECUTIVE DECISION MODEL

The Eight Use Case Selection Gates

Every idea must pass the same evidence standard before funding. Scoring supports comparison, but a hard failure in data authority, risk, ownership or feasibility overrides an attractive value score.

Stage	Gate	Required conclusion	Decision evidence
01	Problem	Specific workflow or customer pain	Problem statement and baseline evidence
02	Value	Measurable economic or service outcome	Benefits model and accountable owner
03	Users	Clear users, decisions and adoption path	Journey, workflow and change hypothesis
04	Data	Accessible, lawful and sufficiently representative	Inventory, quality and authority review
05	Feasibility	Achievable integration and model approach	Architecture option and delivery estimate
06	Risk	Acceptable impact and controllability	Risk tier, mitigations and oversight
07	Evidence	Pilot can prove or disprove the thesis	Evaluation plan and success thresholds
08	Scale	Repeatable economics and operating ownership	Unit economics, service model and roadmap

Decision Rule

A failed hard gate moves the initiative to Prepare or Monitor. A strong narrative, senior sponsor or attractive market cannot replace missing authority, evidence, delivery capacity or operating control.

SECTION 01

Readiness Framework

Translate ambition into a shared executive view of value, evidence, capability and risk.



MANAGEMENT ASSESSMENT MODEL

Readiness Dimensions

Dimension	Decision area	Management evidence	Status
01	Strategic alignment	Priority outcome, sponsor and urgency	Confirmed / Developing / Gap
02	Value potential	Revenue, cost, risk, experience or capacity	Confirmed / Developing / Gap
03	Time to evidence	Speed to a decision-quality pilot result	Confirmed / Developing / Gap
04	Data readiness	Access, quality, authority and representativeness	Confirmed / Developing / Gap
05	Delivery feasibility	Architecture, skills, partners and integration	Confirmed / Developing / Gap
06	Risk and adoption	Impact, oversight, trust and workflow change	Confirmed / Developing / Gap

Evidence Standard

Assessments should distinguish verified evidence from management confidence. Where evidence is incomplete, record the gap, owner, completion date and decision that depends on it.

STRATEGIC READINESS DEPENDENCIES

What Readiness Depends On

Dependency	Why it matters	Evidence management should expect
Problem	Specific workflow or customer pain	Problem statement and baseline evidence
Value	Measurable economic or service outcome	Benefits model and accountable owner
Users	Clear users, decisions and adoption path	Journey, workflow and change hypothesis
Data	Accessible, lawful and sufficiently representative	Inventory, quality and authority review
Feasibility	Achievable integration and model approach	Architecture option and delivery estimate
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ROALLA Interpretation

Dependencies should be evaluated as a connected system. A weakness in ownership, data, architecture, delivery or governance can change the economics and risk of an otherwise attractive initiative.

SECTION 02

Detailed Readiness Assessment

Convert executive intent into verifiable requirements, accountable evidence and clear remediation actions.



READINESS CHECKLIST

Use Case Discovery Quality

Completion standard Mark Ready only when the supporting evidence has been verified. Assign an evidence owner to every open item.

Gate	Readiness requirement	Ready	Gap	Evidence owner
A01	The problem is observed in a defined customer or employee workflow.	☐	☐	_____
A02	A named business owner is accountable for the outcome and adoption.	☐	☐	_____
A03	The current baseline is measured using credible operational or customer data.	☐	☐	_____
A04	The proposed AI role is specific and narrower than the full process transformation.	☐	☐	_____
A05	Users and affected parties have been interviewed or observed.	☐	☐	_____
A06	The expected value is separated into revenue, cost, capacity, quality and risk effects.	☐	☐	_____
A07	Non-AI alternatives and simpler automation options have been considered.	☐	☐	_____
A08	The use case can be piloted without an irreversible platform commitment.	☐	☐	_____
A09	The organization can identify a clear decision at the end of discovery.	☐	☐	_____
A10	Dependencies on other programs, vendors, data and process changes are visible.	☐	☐	_____

READINESS CHECKLIST CONTINUED

Prioritization and Portfolio Readiness

Completion standard Use Gap to create a dated remediation action and identify the management decision that cannot proceed.

Gate	Readiness requirement	Ready	Gap	Evidence owner
B01	All candidate use cases use the same scoring definitions and evidence standard.	☐	☐	_____
B02	Hard gates are assessed before weighted scores are compared.	☐	☐	_____
B03	Benefits are adjusted for adoption, delivery time, operating cost and confidence.	☐	☐	_____
B04	Data readiness is validated by accountable owners rather than assumed by sponsors.	☐	☐	_____
B05	Architecture estimates include integration, security, monitoring and support.	☐	☐	_____
B06	Privacy, safety, fairness and human-oversight requirements affect the score.	☐	☐	_____
B07	The portfolio identifies shared data, platform and governance enablers.	☐	☐	_____
B08	Quick wins do not crowd out foundational or strategically differentiating investments.	☐	☐	_____
B09	Each selected initiative has a discovery budget, owner, milestone and stop condition.	☐	☐	_____
B10	Management reviews actual results and re-ranks the portfolio at a defined cadence.	☐	☐	_____

WEIGHTED EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Readiness Scorecard

Dimension	Weight	Evidence standard	Score	Status
Strategic alignment	20%	Priority outcome, sponsor and urgency	___/20	Strong / Developing / Gap
Value potential	20%	Revenue, cost, risk, experience or capacity	___/20	Strong / Developing / Gap
Time to evidence	15%	Speed to a decision-quality pilot result	___/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Data readiness	15%	Access, quality, authority and representativeness	___/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Delivery feasibility	15%	Architecture, skills, partners and integration	___/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Risk and adoption	15%	Impact, oversight, trust and workflow change	___/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
TOTAL	100%	Weighted executive assessment	___/100	Pursue / Prepare / Monitor

Decision Thresholds

Score	Posture	Management decision
75 to 100	PURSUE	Proceed to bounded execution subject to no hard-gate failure.
50 to 74	PREPARE	Complete a focused readiness plan before major commitment.
0 to 49	MONITOR	Resolve foundational gaps before investing further.

A single material hard-gate failure overrides the weighted score. ROALLA also applies judgment where administrative readiness is high but strategic value, adoption or commercial viability is weak.

SECTION 03

Execution and Advisory Roadmap

Sequence decisions, evidence and delivery so management can invest with confidence and stop weak initiatives early.



READINESS OPERATING PLAN

Recommended 90 Day Mobilization

Timing	Focus	Key activities	Management output
Days 1 to 15	Mobilize	Confirm sponsor, scope, decision rights, evidence request and priority outcomes.	Approved mandate and fact base
Days 16 to 35	Assess	Review current evidence, interview owners, score readiness and identify hard gates.	Verified gaps and risk view
Days 36 to 55	Design	Define target operating, architecture, control and delivery options with economics.	Decision-ready options
Days 56 to 75	Validate	Test assumptions with users, data, technology, vendors and accountable control owners.	Evidence-backed recommendation
Days 76 to 90	Authorize	Approve the roadmap, owners, funding, measures, next gate and stop conditions.	Executive investment decision

Twelve to Twenty Four Month Path

- Quarter 1: establish the fact base, governance and one bounded priority initiative.
- Quarter 2: prove value and control effectiveness in a production-relevant pilot.
- Quarters 3 and 4: scale reusable capabilities, operating ownership and benefits realization.
- Year 2: optimize economics, institutionalize governance and refresh the portfolio using measured results.

ROALLA ADVISORY MODEL

How ROALLA Can Help

ROALLA acts as the technology and commercialization advisor coordinating strategy, evidence, architecture, governance, partners and executive decisions. The objective is not to maximize activity. It is to direct management effort toward investments that are valuable, controllable and executable.

ROALLA workstream	Executive value
Executive diagnostic	Establish the current fact base, hard gates, readiness score and management decisions.
Strategy and portfolio	Translate corporate priorities into a bounded, sequenced investment portfolio.
Architecture and data	Define target capabilities, integration, data, model, cloud and operating patterns.
Governance and risk	Design decision rights, policies, evidence, controls, monitoring and escalation.
Commercial and financial case	Model customer value, productivity, cost, funding, timing and benefits realization.
Vendor and partner ecosystem	Structure evaluation, sourcing, research, delivery and commercial relationships.
Execution readiness	Build roadmaps, work plans, budgets, measures, owners and decision gates.
Ongoing assurance	Monitor the portfolio, challenge evidence and bring decision-ready options to leadership.

Recommended Initial Mandate

- Four-week executive readiness diagnostic using this guide.
- Prioritized decision and evidence map with Pursue, Prepare and Monitor recommendations.
- One flagship initiative dossier with roadmap, economics, architecture and control plan.
- Executive readout and 90-day mobilization plan with accountable owners.

CONTROL FRAMEWORK

Key Risks and Controls

Risk	Exposure	ROALLA control
Idea volume	The loudest sponsor wins the portfolio.	Use one evidence standard and transparent scoring.
Solution bias	Teams select technology before defining the problem.	Start with workflow, outcome and alternatives.
Inflated value	Benefits ignore adoption, time and operating cost.	Apply confidence and realization adjustments.
Hidden data gap	Data access and quality are assumed.	Require owner-confirmed data evidence.
Pilot theatre	A demonstration cannot support a scale decision.	Define production-relevant tests and thresholds.
Risk blindness	Impact is assessed after selection.	Classify risk before ranking.
Fragmentation	Use cases create duplicate platforms and controls.	Prioritize shared enablers and architecture patterns.
No exit	Weak initiatives continue because of sunk cost.	Use explicit stop, pivot and scale gates.

Professional Advice

Qualified legal, privacy, security, tax, accounting, employment and regulatory advisors should validate matters within their professional scope. ROALLA coordinates those inputs with technology strategy, architecture, commercialization, governance and transformation decisions.

OFFICIAL EVIDENCE BASE

Selected Official Sources

These sources support the management principles summarized in this guide. Standards, laws, guidance and organizational obligations continue to evolve and must be confirmed for the specific context before acting.

NIST AI Risk Management Framework. [Official source](#) — Voluntary framework for governing, mapping, measuring and managing AI risk.

NIST Generative AI Profile. [Official source](#) — Companion risk profile for generative AI systems and use cases.

ISO IEC 42001 AI management systems. [Official source](#) — Management-system approach for responsible AI governance and continual improvement.

Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada AI guidance. [Official source](#) — Canadian privacy guidance for organizations developing or using AI.

Government of Canada Digital Standards. [Official source](#) — User-centred, secure, accessible and iterative digital-service principles.

Advisory Disclaimer

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